Latin neighbors while continuing to resist the Communist penetration of Central America, and to do the best we could to unsnarl the continuing mess in the Middle East. At that point in early 1985, it had been almost a year since the marines had left Beirut, and the situation in the Middle East was more tangled and more violent than ever:

• Israeli and Syrian forces still occupied much of Lebanon. With Soviet aid, the Syrian government had undertaken a massive rearmament program to gain “strategic parity” with Israel. Meanwhile, taking sides in a dispute between moderate and radical elements of the Palestine Liberation Organization, Syria had offered refuge to some of this organization’s most fanatical members.
• The Palestinians, who once seemed willing to let moderate Arab nations, including Saudi Arabia and Jordan, represent their interests whenever negotiations were held on a permanent peace solution, were becoming more independent-minded. The PLO was demanding a seat at the negotiating table. We knew the Israelis would climb the wall over that idea.
• The unremitting violence of the Lebanese civil war was devastating what was left of that country, once a glamorous gateway to the Middle East.
• Our intelligence experts were continuing to uncover new links between Libya and terrorism around the world.
• In Teheran, the brutal regime of Ayatollah Khomeini was summarily executing hundreds of Iranians and trying to export the Islamic revolution to neighboring countries.
• There were reports that the ayatollah was in ill health and that his death was near, raising the possibility of new instability in this strategic country that the Soviets almost certainly would try to exploit.
• Stalemated in its war with Iraq, Iran was threatening to block lawful shipping through the Gulf of Hormuz, and both